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PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Friday, 20th June, 2025

The House met at 2.07 p.m.

[MR SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to the item numbered 5, *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We will start from page 1...7—

Prof Kingsley Nyarko?

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, on page 7, the item numbered 4(29), “Nkrumah, Kojo Oppong...” at the second column, yesterday, he was in the House, and I saw him. To be sure my eyes were not deceiving me, I called him this morning, and he confirmed he was here. I am sure Table Office mistakenly marked him as absent. So, I plead that his name is deleted from those absent and sent to those who were present.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Table, kindly check the register and if, indeed, he was here—of course, I saw him—you acknowledge that correction.

Yes, my Brother from Afadjato South?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, let me seek your guidance. I recall, a couple of days ago, the learned Prof Nyarko brought this same issue on the floor of the House. It has to do with item numbered 5 on page 7, “Recognition of Schools/Visitors”. My understanding of this is that, apart from your good self, respected Members of Parliament and staff of Parliament, any other group or individuals who come here are acknowledged as visitors. So, I do not know why we should keep creating two categories for schools and visitors. This is because students, chiefs, market women and everyone who gain access here, with your due permission, does so as a visitor. But I lie entirely in your judgement anyway.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, your position is to know the distinction that has been created for different visitors.

Mr Afriyie: Absolutely so, Mr Speaker. Every visitor is a visitor.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Prof Nyarko?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, this issue has been recurring. At times, the heading is “Recognition of Schools” when only schools are captured. At times, there are some visitors as well, so that is why we

Votes and Proceedings and the Official Report

have schools and visitors. But in this particular case, it reads:

“The Hon Second Deputy Speaker thanked the visitors for coming to observe proceedings of the day.”

They are all visitors, so that one is all right; it is not wrong. But what he is trying to seek clarity on is that because all are visitor; at times, schools would not be here, and there would be only visitors. Other times, there is a mixture of students and visitors. So, we try to bring that distinction.

I remember the other day when I brought this matter up, the Speaker said that the heading is schools/visitors, and I conceded. I always look at where Mr Speaker will thank them. If it is only schools, then the thanks will go to the schools, but if it is a mixture of visitors—They are all visitors. When it is only schools, we can decide to restrict it to the pupils and staff. If it is a mixture, then we can make them visitors then we are good to go.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I think this should not be an issue to split hairs over. They are all visitors in a way, whether they are students, foreign dignitaries or whatever it is. In the House, as you rightly said, apart from Members of Parliament, staff and Ministers of State who are coming to do Business here, every other person who enters here is, indeed, a stranger. So, if he comes here officially to witness what goes on, then he is a visitor. So, let us not split hairs over this. I think we can put all of them together as visitors.

So, we turn to page 8—

Hon Member, are you on your feet?

Page 9...11—

Prof Nyarko?

2.17 p.m.

Mr Speaker, at page 11, the item numbered 1, under “Opening”, let us begin from the first sentence; it reads:

“The Committee embarked on a monitoring visit on Wednesday, 21st May, 2025 at 9.30 a.m. to the Ministry for Gender...”

It should be the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection. Then for the Residential Homes listed, there is:

- “(i) Save Them Young Orphanage;
- (ii) Great Mission International Orphanage; and
- (iii) New Life Nungua Orphanage”.

I am just suggesting that if we could get the location of these orphanages, so that we are specific enough. So, Save Them Young Orphanage, where are they? Great Mission International Orphanage, where are they? New Life Nungua Orphanage, one might think it is at Nungua, but it might be at a different place.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Table, kindly take note of the

Votes and Proceedings and the Official Report

grammar that has been corrected, it should be “Ministry of”; just take note of that.

Page 12...13?

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 19th June, 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, we have the Leader of the House here. We would turn to the item numbered 6, which deals with the Business Statement for the ensuing fifth week.

Respectfully, Leader of the House?

BUSINESS OF THE HOUSE

Chairman of the Business Committee/Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, your

Committee met yesterday, Thursday, 19th June, 2025, and arranged Business of the House for the fifth week, ending Friday, 27th June, 2025.

Mr Speaker, the Committee accordingly submits its Report as follows:

Arrangement of Business

Formal Communications by the Speaker

Mr Speaker, you may read any available communication to the House.

Question(s)

Mr Speaker, the Business Committee has scheduled the following Ministers to respond to Questions asked of them during the week:

No. of Question(s)

Minister for the Interior	5
Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment	2
Minister for Education	5
Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection	2
Minister for Environment, Science and Technology	6
Minister for Finance	10
Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts	2
Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development	3

Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations	7
Minister for Health	5
Minister for Energy and Green Transition	9
xii. Youth Development and Empowerment	2
Total Number of Questions	<u>58</u>

Mr Speaker, in all, 12 Ministers are expected to attend upon the House to respond to 58 Questions during the week. The Questions are of the following types:

- i. Urgent — 19;
- ii. Oral — 39

Statements

Mr Speaker, pursuant to Order 91(2), Ministers of State may be permitted to make Statements on Government policy. You may also admit Statements by Hon Members in accordance with Order 93.

Bills, Papers and Reports

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 159, Bills may be presented to the House for First Reading. However, those of urgent nature may be taken through the various stages in a day in accordance with Order 160.

Pursuant to Order 97, Papers may be laid during the week and reports from Committees may also be presented to the House for consideration.

Motions and Resolutions

Mr Speaker, Motions may be debated and their consequential Resolutions, if any, taken during the week.

Conclusion

Mr Speaker, in accordance with Order 216(2) and subject to Order 67, the Committee submits to the House the order in which the Business of the House shall be taken during the week.

Tuesday, 24th June, 2025

Roll Call

National Pledge

Statements

Urgent Questions

- (a) **Mr Samuel Atta-Mills (Komenda/Edina/Eguafo/Abrem):** To ask the Minister for Education why some teachers do not have staff ID numbers and have not been paid for several months.

- (b) **Mr Eric Nana Agyemang-Prempeh (Ahafo Ano North):** To ask the Minister for the Interior the measures the Ministry is implementing to investigate the interception of over GH¢1million cash hidden in 68 fertiliser bags aboard a commercial vehicle at Juapong, which occurred on 3rd June, 2025.
- (c) **Mr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu (Madina):** To ask the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment the measures being taken to introduce a regime to ensure five per cent minimum employment of persons with Disabilities (PWDs) in all public and private sector institutions in Ghana.
- (d) **Ms Fatahiya Abdul-Aziz (Savelugu):** To ask the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection the transitional measures the Ministry has instituted for caterers who were engaged under the previous Administration's School Feeding Programme but have had their contracts terminated by the current Government, particularly those who were verified to have delivered satisfactory performance.

Education when the following stalled GETFund projects and STEM schools in the Weija-Gbawe Constituency will be completed: (i) Gbawe Methodist Basic '3' (ii) St. Jude R/C Basic School (iii) Weija Presbyterian Primary (iv) Gbawe Cluster of Schools fence wall.

*176. **Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni (Nalerigu/Gambaga):** To ask the Minister for Education the status of the new campus of the Gambaga College of Education which started in 2016.

*177. **Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Odododiodioo):** To ask the Minister for Education an update on the stalled Ayalolo Cluster of Schools Project in Odododiodioo and the steps being taken to ensure its completion.

*178 **Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Odododiodioo):** To ask the Minister for Education an update on the Richard Akwei Memorial School Project in Odododiodioo, given concerns regarding the structural integrity of the facility and its potential safety risks.

*148. **Ms Shirley Kyei (Atwima Nwabiagya South):** To ask the Minister for the Interior why foreign nationals who engaged in illegal mining were deported instead of prosecuting them.

*169. **Mr Frank Asiedu Bekoe (Suhum):** To ask the Minister for the Interior the state of the interception of an alleged massive haul of counterfeit United States dollars, Ghanaian cedi notes, and suspected gold bars hidden in 20-foot containers at a warehouse in Sapeiman on 9th March, 2025.

Questions

*150. **Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (Weija-Gbawe):** To ask the Minister for

***171. Mr Frank Asiedu Bekoe (Suhum):** To ask the Minister for the Interior an update on arrests made on 4th March, 2025, on the Cape Coast to Takoradi highway in respect of some substances alleged to be illicit drugs.

***172. Mr Frank Asiedu Bekoe (Suhum):** To ask the Minister for the Interior the current status of the implementation of the National Security Strategy outlined by H. E. Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo in the year 2020.

***241. Ms Fatahiya Abdul-Aziz (Savelugu):** To ask the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment what safeguard and bilateral arrangements have been put in place under the “Work Abroad Programme” implemented in partnership with the Youth Employment Agency and the United Arab Emirates to ensure the protection, welfare and fair treatment of Ghanaian youth offered opportunities in Abu Dhabi under this programme.

***45. Ms Patricia Appiagyei (Asokwa):** To ask the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology when the Computer Numerical Control (CNC) machine tooling project will be commissioned and made operational.

***47. Mr John Darko (Suame):** To ask the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology the steps the Ministry is taking to address the plastic waste menace in the Country.

***78. Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku (Offinso South):** To ask the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology

the steps the Ministry is taking to address the upsurge in the use of unapproved pesticides and herbicides.

***99. Mr Richard Kwami Sefe (Anlo):** To ask the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology how much of the US\$150M released by the World Bank through the West Africa Coastal Area (WACA) programme was allocated to the protection of sections of the coastlines of Anloga Municipal Assembly and when the project will commence.

***100. Mr Richard Kwami Sefe (Anlo):** To ask the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology the current status of the West Africa Coastal Area (WACA) programme in the Anlo Constituency of the Volta Region and when the work on coastal protection will begin.

***129. Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey (Keta):** To ask the Minister of Environment, Science and Technology the status of US\$155 Million World Bank Grant and Loan to help restore the country’s degraded coastal areas under WACA 2 Resilience Investment Project to protect the Volta and Greater Accra coastal areas.

***147. Ms Gloria Owusu (Trobu):** To ask the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection the measures the Ministry is implementing to ensure that caterers are paid their outstanding arrears for the second term of the 2024/2025 given the abrupt termination of contracts for caterers under the Ghana School Feeding Programme (GSFP).

Presentation of Papers

- (a) Report of the Appointments Committee on His Excellency the President's Nominations for appointments as Justices of the Supreme Court of Ghana.

Motions

Adoption of the Report of the Appointments Committee on His Excellency the President's Nominations for appointments as Justices of the Supreme Court of Ghana.

Committee sittings.

Wednesday, 25th June, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

Urgent Questions

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (Effutu): To ask the Minister for Finance what progress has been made regarding the establishment of the Women's Development Bank for which an amount of GH¢51,268,180.00 was allocated as Seed Capital in the 2025 Budget and when the bank is expected to commence operations.

- (b) **Dr Kingsley Agyemang (Abuakwa South):** To ask the Minister of Finance what plans have been put in place to resolve the tension among commuters as a result of the recent directive by

the National Insurance Commission (NIC) to increase the compulsory Third Party Motor insurance premiums by 10 per cent effective 1st February, 2025.

- (c) **Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku (Offinso South):** To ask the Minister for Finance what measures the Ministry is putting in place to prevent the upsurge of cocoa smuggling across the borders of our country.

- (d) **Dr Tiah Abdul Kabiru Mahama (Walewale):** To ask the Minister for Finance to provide a detailed breakdown of gold exports and foreign exchange earnings generated by the Ghana Gold Board since its inception

- (e) **Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (Kwabre East):** To ask the Minister for Finance the measures being considered to respond to the recent request of COCOBOD for a portion of the Cash Reserve Ratio (CPR), specifically 2-3 per cent of the idle reserve of commercial banks to provide seed funding for indigenous Licensed Buying Companies (LBCs) ahead of the 2025/2026 cocoa season.

- (f) **Ms Fatahiya Abdul-Aziz (Savelugu):** To ask the Minister for Finance the measures instituted to compensate market women and traders affected by the recent market fires at

Kantamanto (Accra), Techiman market, Tamale Timber market, Kwadaso Wood market and Konongo-Odumasi market, who have suffered losses since January 2025.

- (g) **Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (Effia):** To ask the Minister for Finance what plans have been implemented to deal with the energy sector debt following the suspension of the energy sector shortfall and debt repayment levy.

Questions

*168. **Dr Kingsley Agyemang (Abuakwa South):** To ask the Minister for Finance, following the implementation of VAT on non-life insurance, what measures have been put in place to mitigate the potential decline in demand for non-life insurance products (e.g., fire), which have become even more relevant during the recent fire outbreaks.

*196. **Dr Tiah Abdul Kabiru Mahama (Walewale):** To ask the Minister for Finance the alternative financing measures being implemented to support indigenous Licensed Buying Companies (LBC) in the absence of a syndicated loan and associated seed funding for the 2024/2025 and 2025/2026 cocoa seasons.

*197. **Mr Tweneboah Kodua Fokuo (Manso Nkwanta):** To ask the Minister for Finance the extent to which fiscal policies have fulfilled the expected

economic recovery promises outlined in the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Manifesto.

*92. **Mr Frank Yeboah (Atwima Nwabiagya North):** To ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts the plans of the Ministry to revamp and promote tourist sites at Barekese Dam, Owabi Dam and the Wildlife Sanctuary which have immense eco-tourism potential but suffer low patronage and limited infrastructure in the Atwima Nwabiagya North Municipality.

*237. **Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (Offinso North):** To ask the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts the plans of the Ministry on the recent allocation of GH¢22 million for the rehabilitation of six forts and castles across the country.

*226. **Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (Fanteakwa South):** To ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development why artisanal fisheries are not subject to a closed season to benefit spawning and increase fish stocks.

*227. **Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (Fanteakwa South):** To ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development what support has been provided to promote inland aquaculture as an alternative livelihood for displaced food crop farmers in the Fanteakwa South Constituency.

*228. **Mr Seth Osei-Akoto (Atwima Mponua):** To ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development about the immediate measures the Ministry is implementing to sanitise Ghana's fishing sector in light of the European Union's warning that Ghana faces a potential red card.

Presentation of Papers

Motions

Committee sittings.

Thursday, 26th June, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

Urgent Questions

(a) **Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (Effutu):** To ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations the circumstances that necessitated the closure of the following radio stations (i) Fire Group of Companies, Sunyani 90.1MHz, (ii) 1-Zar Consult Limited, Tamale 89.7 MHz. Abo channel Media Group, Adidome 105.7MHz, (iii) Okyeame Radio Limited, Bibiani 99.7 MHz, (iv) Mume Bono Foundation Techiman, 99.7MHz, (v) Osikani Community FM, Nkrankwata, 99.7 MHz, (vi) Gumah FM Station.

(b) **Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (Effutu):** To ask the Minister for Communications, Digital Technology and Innovations the immediate cybersecurity measures being implemented on digital platforms following the hacking of President Mahama's X account on 18th March, 2025.

(c) **Ms Patricia Appiagyei (Asokwa):** To ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations the projected timeline for the completion and full operationalisation of the Digital Youth Village (DYV) project at the University of Ghana, which is currently at 70 per cent completion.

(d) **Nana Ampaw Kwame Addo-Frempong (Abuakwa North):** To ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations the circumstances surrounding the sudden dismissal of five zonal managers of the National Communications Authority in Koforidua, Ho, Takoradi, Bolgatanga and Tamale Zonal officers

(e) **Mr Charles Asuako Owiredu (Abirem):** To ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovation to provide details on the terms of the agreement with Canada-based Rektron Group for the acquisition

of a 60 per cent stake in AT Ghana including the financial valuation, safeguards for national interests and measures to ensure the deal enhances telecommunications infrastructure and affordability for Ghanaians.

Questions

***142. Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (Effia):** To ask the Minister for Communications, Digital Technology and Innovations the circumstances that led to the hacking of the account of the president of Ghana and what efforts have been made to avoid its future occurrence.

***238. Mr Peter Lanchene Toobu (Wa West):** To ask the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations when the over 50 communities which include the following, will have network connectivity (i) Dabo (ii) Gurungu (iii) Kuukyileyiri (iv) Vieri (v) Lassie

***195. Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (Weija-Gbawe):** To ask the Minister for Health the measures being implemented to address the concerns of 30,000 trained but unemployed health workers who are demanding posting despite critical staff shortages in health facilities across the nation.

***194. Mr Peter Lanchene Toobu (Wa West):** To ask the Minister for Health when the construction of the following three health centres in the Wa West District, which have been abandoned since 2017, will be

completed: (i) Gurungu (ii) Vieri (iii) Eggu

***152. Dr Kingsley Agyemang (Abuakwa South):** To ask the Minister for Health what concrete steps the Ministry is taking to ensure timely reimbursement to health service providers under NHIS to prevent future disruptions that directly impact vulnerable citizens.

***153. Dr Kingsley Agyemang (Abuakwa South):** To ask the Minister for Health the plans of the Ministry to improve oral health as the 2023 WHO STEPS survey reveals a devastating state of oral health in Ghana.

***156. Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (Odododiodioo):** To ask the Minister for Health the measures instituted to address the long-standing shortage of resident paediatricians or doctors at Princess Marie Louise Children's Hospital in Accra.

Presentation of Papers

Motions

Committee sittings.

Friday, 27th June, 2025

Roll Call

Statements

Urgent Questions

(a) **Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (Effutu):** To

ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition what reforms are being implemented at ECG to mitigate illegal electricity connection and meeting challenges to improve revenue efficiency.

(b) **Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (Effutu):** To ask the Minister for Youth and Development and Empowerment what specific measures the Ministry is undertaking to complete the four outstanding Youth Resource Centres in Dormaa Ahenkro, Dunwa, Axim and Ho and when these centres are expected to be fully operational.

(c) **Ms Fatahiya Abdul-Aziz (Savelugu):** To ask the Minister for Youth Development and Empowerment the measures instituted to ensure that National Service Personnel trained in agribusiness and cocoa farming receive post-training support, including land access, logistics, or markets to ensure sustainability.

Questions

*170. **Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (Effutu):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition what specific measures are being implemented by the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG) to reduce technical and commercial losses under the Loss Reduction Programme.

*133. **Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey (Keta):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition what strategies are being implemented to enhance revenue collection in order to reduce debt accumulation in the energy sector.

*134. **Mr Kwame Dzudzorli Gakpey (Keta):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the outstanding financial obligation to contractors and suppliers from 2017 – 2024.

*215. **Mr Robert Wisdom Cudjoe (Prestea Huni-Valley):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition when the following communities will be captured under the Rural Electrification Programme: (i) Bepoase (ii) Gambia (iii) Alhassan (iv) Bayire Agya (v) Nkran Dadieso (vi) Takyie Mantia (vii) Entoada.

*216. **Mr Robert Wisdom Cudjoe (Prestea Huni-Valley):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the specific steps the Ministry is taking to resume the stalled rural electrification works in the following communities within the Prestea Huni Valley Constituency: (i) Subre Nkwanta (ii) Kwasi Kokor (iii) Pewodie (iv) Nazareth (v) Nyamease (vi) Kofikrom (vii) Nyame Bekyere.

*145. **Mr Kwadwo Damoah (Jaman South):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the steps the Ministry is taking to address the loopholes in the inventory management system of the Electricity Company of

Ghana (ECG), to prevent such discrepancies in the future, following the report of 27th May, 2025 regarding the recovery of the 2,637 ECG containers at the Tema Port while 54 containers remain unaccounted for and provide an update on the status of the 54 missing containers.

***146. Mr Michael Kwasi Aidoo (Oforikrom):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the measures the Ministry has implemented to avert the imminent shutdown of the Karpowership power plant.

***212. Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah (Ahafo Ano South West):** To ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the progress of the installation of transformers in the following communities in the Ahafo Ano Constituency: (i) Achiase (ii) Kunsu (iii) Mankraso.

Presentation of Papers

Motions

Committee sittings.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Leader of the House.

Hon Members, the Business Statement for the ensuing fifth week has been read to us. If there is any issue or comment a Member may want to discuss, this is the time. I notice the Hon Member for Effia.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity. Let me commend, first and

foremost, the Leader of Government Business for sharing with this honourable House the Business Statement for next week.

Mr Speaker, I can see and I need to appreciate the Minister's inclusion of some of the Urgent Questions that have been posed, particularly the one as regards the suspension of Government's GH¢1.00 per litre, which we want the Minister for Finance to come and explain the measures to deal with it.

However, I think the Leader as well would help us a lot with this persistent Presentation of Paper which have not been dealt with. Consistently in our Order Paper, we have "Reports of Leadership on the Composition of Membership of ECOWAS Parliament and Pan-African Parliament". It has been recurring week after week in the Order Paper and we have still not had that issue dealt with. I believe it is high time Leadership takes particular notice of it, and gets this particular matter resolved.

Mr Speaker, I think that will be my initial submission.

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Let me turn to Prof Kingsley Nyarko.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I am grateful for your indulgence. I have seen a lot of Questions admitted to be answered by the Ministers and those who the Questions refer to. I would like to

read Order 88(6) and seek your guidance on how we can ensure that we get our Ministers and heads of constitutional Bodies to attend upon the House to answer our Questions.

Mr Speaker, Order 88(6) says:

“In the absence of the Minister, Member or Head of the Independent Constitutional Body to whom the Question is directed, the Speaker may permit an authorised person to respond to the Question.”

My point is that because this Order is clear, a Minister might not be able to be in the House because of some engagement. However, somebody with an authority can answer the Question. It could be a Deputy, and per my understanding, any other person that the Minister designates to answer the Question.

I am just pleading with the Leader of the House that if a Minister is not able to attend upon the House to respond to Questions, somebody must be available. Not that when the Question is called, we are told that the Minister is not there. Else, we will have Questions upon Questions compiled.

Mr Speaker, at times, we have a tall Business for a day's Sitting and if we do not get Ministers to respond to the Questions and they come to the House later, we go beyond the five hours and at times, we can even do 10 hours. So, I am just asking that somebody must be ready to answer the Questions when the Minister is not there.

My second issue has to do with debates in the House or comments on Statements. Mr Speaker, if you go to Order 115(1), it reads:

“Subject to the discretion of the Speaker and Order 169(3)(b), a Member who intends to speak shall rise in the Member's place and address the Chair while standing only after catching the eye of the Speaker.”

In recent times, this rule is overlooked. When it is time for us to debate on any Motion or comment on Statements, Leaders will identify who to speak. I do not see that in our Orders. The Order is clear; a Member must stand in their place and catch the eye of the Speaker.

Mr Speaker, you can use your discretion and say that you are allowing maybe two or three contributions, but the Member must stand and he or she must catch your eye. I do not think that it is within the powers of the Leaders to determine who should speak and who should not. I am just bringing this to the attention of the Leader, so that Members would not feel that there is some form of selectivity. Let Members be confident and rise. It is the duty of the Speaker to ignore or recognise that person.

Mr Speaker, these are the issues I wanted to bring to the attention of my respected Majority Leader.

Thank you.

2.27 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, I think the Leader will speak to the two issues you have raised, but I think with the first one you raised, that explains why yesterday I allowed the Deputy Chair of the Commission to speak. And for me, if we had brought the Deputy Chair to speak, then like Order 88 clearly states, probably we will be shooting ourselves in the foot. If a Minister is not here, the Deputy cannot come and answer Questions. And if I got what we are saying, it is like, because some of the Ministers are so busy and cannot always be here, we should allow the Deputy Ministers, or by what we are even saying, if the Deputy Minister is not even here, the Hon Minister can designate somebody else to come and answer Questions, so that we do not have questions piled up—

Fine, I may not go with any other person, but with the Deputy Ministers, we should be able to allow them to come and respond to Questions if the substantive Ministers are not here. And the issue that you have raised, as I have said, the Leader will address them, but the issue concerning the comment among others, we will also be working on time. Even though the Standing Orders is saying that we should use one hour for Statements, we sometimes use three hours. So, we need to manage the time and that is why we sometimes restrict Members in terms of time or even plead with Members for us to move on. But I think Leadership will have to look at it. Because I share with you that the Leadership will have to probably appoint

someone or select someone to speak. It could be that that person is not even ready to speak at that moment. So, I hope the Leader will take time to address some of these issues.

Yes, Hon Member for Okere?

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I also want to commend the Leader for the Business Statement and also follow suit on my senior Colleague, Prof Nyarko, on the Standing Orders.

Mr Speaker, on 5th June, 2025, I raised an issue regarding laying of Papers and distribution of copies to Members. Mr Speaker and senior Members indicated that after the Papers are laid, they ought to be distributed. Mr Speaker also indicated that because we are in a technological transition, most of these papers are not printed, but they are sent to our consoles. Mr Speaker, as I speak, Papers were laid on that very day.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Which very day?

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, that was on the budget—Just a moment, if I may refer.

Mr Speaker, there was a Paper on, I think—Just a moment. I will make reference as I go along. But on that day, there was a Paper that was laid and I raised the issue that Members did not have copies and Mr Speaker and senior Members indicated that copies of Papers are given to Members after the Paper is laid and referred to Committees. I did

indicate that it is important for Members to have individual copies of Papers that are laid here because the referral of Papers to Committees does not stop Members from having their individual understanding of the works of the Committees, so that once a Committee lays their Paper, Hon Members can make meaningful inputs.

Mr Speaker, from 5th June to date, every single day, I check my mails and the Papers have not been forwarded to us. Other Papers have been laid afterwards and we do not have individual copies of these Papers. Mr Speaker, I just want to bring that to the fore, that once Article 110 provides for our enactment of rules under our Standing Orders, it is important that the grundnorm of this nation ought to be obeyed.

And it is not for any reason why the framers of the Constitution indicate that Members of Parliament must make rules to govern our operations here and when we make these rules, we have to obey them. It is important for us to have copious knowledge of all documentations that come to this House so that when Committees present their Report, we can make informed input.

Mr Speaker, having said that, my second issue is also on the fact that as we move along with this technology, it is important that our Standing Orders reflect the new activities that we have here. Mr Speaker, with your indulgence, Standing Order 48(2) indicates that:

“Before the commencement of a sitting, the Clerk shall send to each

Member a copy of the Votes and Proceedings of the previous sitting”

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, hold on.

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources?

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah): Thank you, Mr Speaker, I think Hon Members are supposed to confine themselves to the Business Statement, and I thought that was what the Member should be doing. I think he is completely going outside the Business Statement.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Member for Okere, I was going to tell you that, so take cue, and we just want to limit ourselves to issues we are going to confront next week, so just look at it from that angle.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, yes, I am laying a foundation in order to make my submission of some issues that border on the Standing Orders that ought to be considered as matters that have to be brought before the House. I understand my senior Colleague, but if he should have allowed me to finish my—Because I started from the issues on 5th June and I indicated that these activities—I have come back to the Standing Order 48 and my submission is that there are some provisions within the Standing Orders that the Business Committee must consider and take advantage of Order 108 to amend. That is where I am going to and that is why I

sought to read Order 48(2), which indicates that:

“Before the commencement of a sitting, the Clerk shall send to each Member a copy of the Votes and Proceedings of the previous sitting”.

I further move to Order 48(6), which says that:

“The Votes and Proceedings shall be in print and is a journal of the House”.

Emphasis on “shall be in print”.

Mr Speaker, my checks from the Director of Publishing indicates that, mostly, they only print and distribute about 80 copies of the *Votes and Proceedings*, and we are moving to technology because most of the *Votes and Proceedings* are sent to our portals.

I am of the view that we should consider taking into consideration Order 108, so that we can seek to amend Order 48(6) to be able to acknowledge the transmission of *Votes and Proceedings* through the technological advancement. Else, the Standing Orders indicate that it “shall”. I am not a lawyer, but I believe that the Leader of the House is a lawyer, and once it says “shall be in print”. Order 48(2) says that “each Member shall have a copy”, and Order 48(6) indicates that it “shall be in print”, but most of us do not get printed copies.

Mr Speaker, the last issue which I indicated is that the Minister for Finance was here on 3rd June and assured this

House that as at the moment that he was speaking, he had transferred some amount of money to the Common Fund Administrator. Mr Speaker, we, as Members of Parliament must encourage efficiency of institutions. For three weeks, this money has been sitting in the Common Fund Administrator and has not been sent to the district assemblies, and these are issues—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hold on.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. Mr Speaker, I would advise my Colleague to check his account or let his DCE check their various accounts.

2.37 p.m.

Mr Ssecond Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please, let us stop this.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Chairman, my Colleague is not current. He does not know what is happening. The money has been transferred to the assemblies — *[Interruption]*— Mr Speaker, I am providing information. He is not current. The issue has been dealt with.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, why would you not allow him, then afterwards, someone will speak?

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I am on a point of order, so the Hon Member cannot come on a point of order against me.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib, you are a leader, and once he finishes, I will give you the opportunity.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Chairman, I am on a point of order, so the Hon Member cannot come on a point of order against me. He should learn the rules.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Nyindam, please, resume your seat. Let him finish, once he finishes, I will give you the opportunity.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, the issue has been dealt with. So, there is no need for my Colleague to repeat it or raise it here. The moneys have been paid.

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Minority Deputy Whip?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, with respect, the Second Deputy Majority Whip is completely out of place in his response. We have the Chairman of the Business Committee who is the Majority Leader who presented the Business of the House. If concerns from Members are raised, it is the Majority Leader who has to respond, not the Majority Deputy Whip. So, what he is doing is completely out of order and it should not be encouraged. Other than that, Members will now be responding to Members in terms of concerns being raised. He is not the one to respond. So, he is completely out of order.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, indeed he

is right. The Leader of the House is capable of responding to any other issue. So, Hon Member, just conclude for me.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, with your indulgence, please give me two more minutes because of the interjections. Mr Speaker, I want to place on record that I am a former District Chief Executive — [*Hear! Hear!*] — and Mr Speaker, the development of this nation, as rightly put by the Majority and the Minister for Finance hinges on local governance and decentralisation and as at this afternoon 1.00 p.m., the moneys had not hit the accounts of the Municipal District Assemblies. It has not and that is a fact.

Mr Speaker, —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: In conclusion, Mr Speaker, I plead with the Members on the other Side that, I have made this point and this is about the development of this country and if we are making such issues, — it is important —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you raised the issue, we have corrected you that, this is the Business of the House; what we intend doing next week. If you have an issue, you can come by way of Statement, or by way of Urgent Question, then you raise all these issues, but you do not just chip in commenting on the Business of the House and just trying to bombard the House with so many things. So, please, this is the Business of the House,

concerning what will be done next week, so let us deal with that.

So, Leader, do you want to respond to all the concerns already raised or should I take more of them?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I agree with the Hon Member about the report on the composition of the membership of ECOWAS and Pan-African Parliament. We are working very hard to — there are some fundamental disagreements, between the two Sides. We could use our numbers to railroad our way, but we want to build consensus and agree on it. So, that is what is holding it. So, the Hon Member can as well talk to his Leader. The composition of the ECOWAS and Pan-African Parliaments, there was a question about that, and that is what I mean. About the Standing Orders and the rule regarding one standing in their place, well, that is what it says, but also, ultimately, the discretion is that of the Speaker. One may not be standing in their place, but if the Speaker decides that one has caught his eye, he can give one the opportunity to speak.

As for the practice of Leaders agreeing on who to speak, while it is a common practice, I think that maybe the manner in which the Speakers enforce it, is what the Hon Member may be complaining about. Maybe those people should always be on their feet, and then the Speaker is guided by the list and pretends that it is a fair and democratic process, but then know that the indication from that side is that it has to be Mr A or Mr B. So, it is the finesse with which we implement our understandings.

As for the Question being answered by Ministers and Deputy Ministers, it has been a long-standing practice of this House that we seek leave and Deputy Ministers Answer the Questions. It has never been denied except that it is always attended with a lot of drama and excitement, but ultimately, leave is granted. But beyond Ministers and Deputy Ministers, no other public or civil servant within any Ministry will be allowed to answer Questions at Plenary. But if it is at Committee, technocrats and civil servants may be permitted to respond to questions asked in relation to their sector.

Also, one notices that even for the Independent Constitutional Bodies, it is not Plenary, it is Committee; Committee of the Whole. So, we downgrade it so that they can also participate. So, at the level of Plenary, it has to be Ministers and Deputy Ministers, because by our Constitution, Ministers and Deputy Ministers are actually Members of Parliament, except that they are non-voting Members of Parliament who are not on Committees, but they are Members of Parliament; they can participate, and debate, except that they cannot vote on matters

On the issue of notice of Proceedings and then also the Agenda and Order Paper, I do not know exactly which provisions you were really focused on, because Order 48(6) says:

“The *Votes* and *Proceedings* shall be in print and is a journal of the House”.

The *Votes and Proceedings* have always been in print — *[Interruption]* — Well, I have not noticed it because I see copies on my desk, so I did not know that they do not print enough copies, but that is a matter that we should look into. If they do not print enough copies, then we need to make sure they print enough copies for Members.

I think also maybe there is some wisdom in amending some of our Orders to recognise the effort to digitise the work that takes place in this Chamber. So, perhaps it will be an interesting project if the Hon Member could proffer some amendments to the Standing Orders to take care of that. I will encourage the Hon Member to do that and that will be his legacy in the House.

As for the question of moneys to assemblies, I am sure that the moneys have been sent. I saw the authorisation two weeks ago. I think that there is something going on. First is the confirmation of all the DCEs and MCEs. Second is the development and approval of the guidelines by Cabinet, because one would not want the money to get there before the guidelines get there. And then lastly, they have all been summoned to Accra, and I think today, they are finishing their orientation programme as DCEs. So, one would want to bring them, orient them, and guide them before one releases the moneys to them. But as for the money, it has been available and ready a very long time. That, I can assure Hon Members, and I can actually give them records of the transmission of the funds to Controller and Accountant General *etcetera*.

2.47 p.m.

So, I believe after their orientation today, they will now be empowered to go back and work based on the guidelines and the orientation they have been given. Let me assure the House that I specifically spoke with His Excellency the President and asked him to chip in his speech, a directive to the Metropolitan, Municipal and District Chief Executives (MMDCEs) to work closely with their Members of Parliament (MPs) and to reduce the friction between them and the MPs. And the President promised to do that. I think he did that in his speech. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me take the last set of comments. Yes, Dr Kabiru Mahama.

Dr Abdul KabiruTiah Mahama: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, let me also commend the Leader of the House for the brilliant Statement. But I want to say two things. I filed a Question, which has been suspended indefinitely, to the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry. She was supposed to appear the week before the last one and last week. Both Questions were deferred because of her inability to come.

I am looking at the Questions programmed for the ensuing week, and we still do not find in the Business Statement, Questions programmed for the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry. And Mr Speaker, it is becoming too much of a no-show for the Minister to keep on not coming to this

House to answer the Question. So, I will want to urge the Leader of the House to try and prevail on the Minister to take the Questions of Members of Parliament seriously, because it has been more than one month. She keeps on postponing the Questions.

And even in the ensuing week, there is no expression of any Question for her. So, we have to take it seriously, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: What I know is that she has written to—

Dr Mahama: The Question was even filed in the last Meeting. She could not come, and she has postponed it about three times this Meeting. It is not good for the House.

Mr Speaker, the last one has to do with the composition of Committees. I wanted to join in on the issue raised by my Colleague. Aside from the Committees expressed in the Order Paper that we have seen, there are also Standing and Select Committees that have not been fully composed. My Colleague here, the MP for Mion, is supposed to be in the Committee on Information and Communication. But each time he wants to appear, they say they have to ratify it by Parliament. So, he has not attended any of our meetings because of this particular issue, and we are working.

Mr Speaker, we must ensure that we make the membership of all other outstanding Committees complete, so that we can do our work. I am also again

appealing to the Leader to prioritise it so that in the ensuing week, we will finish all Standing and Select Committees, so that the Members can get to work.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Habib Iddrisu.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I just want to start from where Dr Kabiru Mahama ended and also appeal to the Majority Leader. On our Side, after the amendments to the Committee, we have our records ready, and those were sent to the Selection Committee. So, Members are supposed to be in various Committees, but that is still a problem because the Majority Side has not sent their amendments to the Selection Committee.

Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Chairman of the Business Committee, when we should be expecting the Mid-Year Budget. It is so important and critical because the Minister for Finance is not spending, and he says he is waiting for the Mid-Year Budget. When the nurses went on a strike, they said the nurses were not budgeted for. So, the nurses are also of the view that maybe if the Mid-Year Budget comes early, whatever their concerns are may be incorporated into it. So, it is critical.

The Minister for Education is here; ask him whether they have released money for the past six months for his Ministry. The Ministers, including the Minister for

Lands and Natural Resources are in the Chamber because they do not have releases. They cannot sit in their Ministry. That is why they are always in the Chamber. If they sit in their Ministry, there is nothing that they can do because there are no releases. They should go to their Ministry.

The Majority Leader will always boast that he has his Ministers in the Chamber, but that is because there are no releases at the Ministries. They cannot be there to work. That is why they are always here. They are hiding in Parliament. They have additional responsibility and cannot use Parliament as a hiding place. They should go to their Ministries and work.

Also, on the Ministers, I want to find out from the Chairman of the Business Committee, President Mahama—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I think enough with that.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: I am moving to another question.

Mr Speaker, President Mahama promised all of us, Ghanaians, that he would appoint 60 Ministers; he has 56 Ministers. It has been six months along the line since he promised Ghanaians. When is the President bringing the remaining four? I know that 10 people from their Side have already been promised the four. I can see the Hon Member for Assin North, the former President's brother, Hon Atta-Mills, and the founder's daughter. None of them has been considered out of the four. But 10

have been promised ministerial positions.

The founder of their party and former President, Flt. Lt. Jerry John Rawlings' daughter who is a Member of Parliament has not been given a position.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, enough.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: When are we expecting the four additional Ministers? Hon Haruna Iddrisu will always say that we should follow due process, and where the Constitution provides something for us to follow, we should. Article 268 provides for a mining lease agreement. The Minister for Lands and Natural Resources is supposed to bring the Damang Gold Mine agreement to Parliament before he extends that. He always promises that he will bring it. The Majority Chief Whip raised it, and he has not been able to bring the agreement of Damang Gold Mine for ratification. When will he bring it?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, like I said to the Hon Member for Okere, if you have issues of an urgent nature, you can come by way of an urgent Statement.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: I want to appeal to the Chairman of the Committee to programme the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to brief us on *galamsey*. He is saying that it is the Chiefs and District Chief Executives (DCEs) who are going to fight *galamsey*. I want to find out whether that is the

policy in fighting *galamsey*. So, he should be programmed.

Also, I want to know if he can programme the Minister for Foreign Affairs, because there is an Israel-Iran war, and Ghanaians are in both countries. We do not know what is actually going on. He has to programme the Minister for Foreign Affairs to appear before the House. When he was a Ranking Member and there was an issue between Ukraine and Russia, he was in Ukraine taking pictures with students. When is he going to Iran? When is the Minister for Foreign Affairs going to Israel? We want to know that.

Let me conclude by telling the Majority Leader that a lot of things including the air conditioners in our Colleagues' offices and our elevators among others are not working. So, I want to appeal to him to see if he can talk to the authorities to address this issue.

I also want to appeal to the Minister for Finance to issue the releases. He should give the Minister's money to work. The economy is dry. There is no money. People are suffering. He is not releasing money. He does not have a release. How can he help his Colleagues? That is why they are now coming into the Chamber. The Minister must release the money and let work go on.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Osahen Afenyo-Markin.

2.57 p.m.

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

It is only through Parliament that we see accountability, and it is only Parliament that has that constitutional mandate to oversee the Executive.

Mr Speaker, last week, we heard Mr President talk about the Iranian-Israeli war and said, in express terms, that the war definitely will have impact on our economy. However curious I found that statement to be, I leave Mr President by his own words and posterity.

Mr Speaker, however, for my purpose, Mr President said he has assigned the Minister for Finance and the Minister for Energy and Green Transition to study the economic impacts of the situation in Iran and Israel and report. The appropriate forum for such action is Parliament. The Minister for Finance and his colleague, Minister for Energy and Green Transition, should come to Parliament and tell us whether or not the Israeli-Iranian war is, at all, having any impact on our economy. Because we were told only yesterday that the Ukrainian-Russian war has no impact at all on our economy. That was what we were told only yesterday.

Mr Speaker, we want the Majority Leader to programme these two Ministers to appear before Parliament and update Parliament of these happenings on our economy.

Mr Speaker, this update will guide us in how we communicate with our constituents. This is a very short Meeting, and we would have a long break. We go to our Constituencies and they ask why the one job, three shifts is not coming, and how would we answer? We go to our constituencies and they ask about the 24-Hour Economy, and how would we answer? We go to our constituencies, and they ask why the One District One Factory (1D1F) been cancelled, and how would we answer?

Mr Speaker, for me, giving us an update would help us make an informed decision. So, we do not want Mr President to just talk, but we want him to involve Parliament so that we will be able to reach out to our people.

Mr Speaker, on that score, I want the Hon Majority Leader to take this matter on board and come back with an appropriate response to the effect that these two Ministers would be programmed. After all, this week, some of them came in with some policy statement. Do they not consider this as an urgent matter to bring to the House on?

Mr Speaker, my second point is that we were in this House when the Majority, relying on their numbers, introduced an Order Paper *Addendum* one evening. There was no discussion on this matter at Conclave, but, sometimes, when the Majority Leader is using his powers, we cannot stop him. So, he used his powers to introduce this Order Paper *Addendum*, and at 10.30 p.m., when many Ghanaians were asleep, they introduced their Energy Sector Levy

(Amendment) Bill, 2025, otherwise known as *Dumsor Levy*.

Mr Speaker, Ghanaians were disappointed. We, the Minority here, expressed our dissent and our disagreement and eventually rejected that Bill which imposes GH¢4.50 per gallon of petrol. Later, when they saw the backlash, they claimed that they are suspending.

Mr Speaker, the right thing to do is to repeal the law. We cannot trust Executive discretion because, the way they introduced it at night, they can reintroduce it at night. If they want Ghanaians to take them seriously, we are the representatives of the people. They should come here and eat a humble pie. This is democracy; one cannot win it every day. They should just come and repeal the law.

Mr Speaker, I would want to encourage the Majority Leader to—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, do not be intimidated. The Majority Leader has forgotten that he was, once upon a time, the midfielder for the opposition.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Nobody is intimidating anybody.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, he should look in my direction. I want an eyeball-to-eyeball contact with him. Mr Speaker, he is intimidating you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, nobody is intimidating anybody. Nobody can intimidate me.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: All right, let me direct it

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: As nobody can intimidate you, nobody can also intimidate me. No, the point is—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: He was playing midfield for the then Minority. He is talking about—Mr Speaker, do not mind him.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, there are so many ways you can come to the House to address this issue.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, do not get into this one.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, I am managing the House now. I am saying there are so many ways you can come to the House to address this issue. You can come by way of urgent Statement; nobody can stop you. But when you just sneak it into Business Statement, obviously, I cannot sit aloof. I will obviously guide you to, at least, manage it. But if you want to come and come properly, have a way of coming. I am here; I will allow you to speak. So, please, this is a Business Statement; let us have a way of addressing it.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we take guidance from the Chair, and it does not matter whether the Chair is a Jew, a Christian or a Gentile. What is

important is that the Chair has advice. So, I take a cue.

Mr Speaker, the mainstay of all I am saying on this second issue is that the Majority Leader should programme the Minister for Finance to appear before us next week to repeal this law under the same Certificate of urgency. It is very important; it would help Ghanaians understand that, indeed, what the Minority said that it was wrong to introduce a *Dumsor* Levy, the Majority has, at least, listened for the first time.

Mr Speaker, these are the two points for now. I want him to respond, so that I come back and deal with some other important issues.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, just come and respond to them, and let us move to something else.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I have taken on board the request that we should try and complete the work of the composition of Committees. So, where there were errors and those Committees remain incomplete, I think that, basically, the two Whips are the ones who are supposed to help us complete this exercise. So, I will follow up with the Whips and make sure that they have done their work.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry has been out of the jurisdiction for a while; that is why her Questions keep being rescheduled. So, I believe that she has officially written to us, indicating that immediately

she returns, she will come and answer her Questions.

On the number of Ministers, I think it is obvious that the problem Ghana has had is with having too many Ministers. It got to a point where we had about 118 Ministers, and the public has been very unhappy with the political class, that is both political parties: National Democratic Congress (NDC) and New Patriotic Party (NPP) in the past for appointing too many Ministers.

3.07 p.m.

The NDC made an effort to reduce the numbers by promising that we will not appoint more than 60 Ministers, and we have done so well that we have not even hit the 60 mark. So, I think that, instead of the Minority Side pushing us to appoint more Ministers, they should rather commend us for having managed the numbers to a point where it appears we may not need 60 Ministers.

Mr Speaker, the President appears to be doing well even with 56 Ministers, and if that is the case, I think that we should be commended highly. So, it should not be an issue that the President has not appointed 60 Ministers. But it is good that he keeps highlighting it because the more he highlights it on this Floor, the more Ghanaians are reminded that the President promised 60 Ministers but has done well not to even appoint 60 Ministers but has rather appointed only 56 Minister. [*Hear! Hear!*]

So, I will be happy if he would raise it every Friday—I will encourage him to

raise it every Friday, so that I will remind Ghanaians that the President promised 60 Ministers but did not even get there; he managed to stop at 56 Ministers. I believe Ghanaians would even want the number reduced but the President promised 60, and he has kept it at 56.

On the issue of the Iran-Israel war, I think the other day the Minister for Foreign Affairs actually wanted to make a Statement on the that and all the issues that it raises pertaining to interests of Ghana. But because he had made a Statement that day and then was answering Questions, I advised that he come on another day to make that Statement. So, I will draw the attention of the Minister for Foreign Affairs to come back and make the Statement.

Now on issue of releases, I should say that the releases are being made, and that is not an issue. On the presence of Ministers in the Chamber, if he would recall, we used to sit from 10:00 in the morning till about 2:00 in the afternoon, and, during that period, we had difficulties getting the Ministers to come and answer Questions.

So, a decision was taken to shift our Sitting to start at 2:00 p.m., and the President issued directives through the Secretary to the President to the Ministers that, now that Parliament starts Sitting at 2 o'clock, no Minister has an excuse for not being in Parliament. So, a directive was issued to the Ministers by the President that they should try and also be present. At least, they can go to their offices at 8:00 a.m., work till 2:00 p.m. and show up at Parliament. If the

Parliamentarians need them, they will see them there. The Parliamentarians would not have to queue at the offices of the Ministers in order to see them.

So, the Ministers come here, so that the Members will have an opportunity to engage them on their constituency matters. That is the whole idea; this is a Government serving its people, by making the Ministers available to Members as representatives of the people. So, they do not have to follow them in their offices to have access; they can have access to them in the Chamber. So, any of the Members of Parliament can always walk to the other Side, engage a Minister on a matter concerning his or her constituency and that saves them having to go to their Ministry.

So, he should be praising the Ministers and thanking this Government for making sure that Ministers are always in the Chamber for the MPs to have access to them. I think he should be thanking them; he should be praising us. They are here; they are on this side—*[Interruptions]*—When the Deputy Minority Whip was making his Statements, they saw so many Ministers, and they were complaining about so many Ministers always being in the Chamber instead of sitting at their Ministries. All of a sudden, they said there is only one.

Mr Speaker, on the issues that the Minority Leader has raised, I am sure that the Minister for Finance will make himself available when it is appropriate to respond to any issues that we may put in a Question for him to respond to. If he

feels that a matter of Government policy needs to be communicated to this House, he will come.

As for the Energy Sector Levy (Amendment) Bill that was passed, if you recall, the argument that was used to back the levy was that it will be enforced to the extent that it will not lead to an increase in the ex-pump price of petroleum products. That was the condition under which this Side of the House accepted the levy. If implementing the levy will lead to an increase in the price of petroleum products, we will not allow that.

Mr Speaker, by that time, petroleum prices were coming down and Government thought to harvest some of the benefits in order to deal with the energy sector financing challenges. When global circumstances change the environment of the pricing of petroleum products and the implementation of the levy will lead to an increase in the price, that goes against the arguments that informed the passage of the Bill. This is a Side that keeps its promise, the promise not to do anything that will increase the price of petroleum products in implementing the levy and cause an increase in the price of petroleum products.

It was on that basis we halted it and when circumstances change and there is the possibility of harvesting the benefits for Ghanaians to solve the energy sector problem, we can go back to it. So, this is a Government that keeps its promises, and we promised not to increase prices, so we will do whatever it takes to keep

prices as low as possible. Mr Speaker, if there is anything that needs to be done, maybe, just tinker with the transitional provisions of the Act.

I think we have answered all the questions.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Business Statement, as read to us, has been thoroughly discussed, and it is hereby adopted.

Hon Members, before we move to the next item, let me invite you to look at the Public Gallery. We have our children who are at the basic, secondary school and even the universities with us. They are here to also monitor what goes on in the Chamber. We have three schools here.

The first school is Mfantshipim Senior High School; they are being led by Gloria Quansah, who is a teacher, and the school is located at the Cape Coast South Constituency; they are 66 in number. I think that is the constituency of Deputy Majority Leader.

You are welcome.

[Students from Mfantshipim Senior High School were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The second school is Legacy Girls' College. They are here with their leader, Peweh Allor. I do not know whether I pronounced it well. He is a teacher, and the school is located in the Lower Manya Krobo Constituency; they are also 59 in number.

[Students from Legacy Girls' College were acknowledged]

3.17 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The last school is Ekwamkrom Methodist Model JHS. They are also being led by Mr Stephen Nyarko, who is the headteacher of the school, and the school is located at Gomoa Central Constituency. They are 214 in number, and I hope we have their MP here—The MP is here.

Thank you.

[Students from Ekwamkrom Methodist Model JHS]

We have the MP here.

Mr Kwame Asare Obeng: *Wɔnyɛ* busy. Relax.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for welcoming my people from Ekwamkrom Methodist Model J.H.S. These kids here are some very brilliant kids, so I promised them that they would enjoy free first year university education. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member? So, the guests at the Public Gallery, you are all students, notwithstanding whichever level you are. I hope you are taking a close look at whatever is going on here. We want to urge you on to study hard so that tomorrow, you can come and take over from us if we are no more here. You are most welcome, and I wish you well.

Yes, Leadership?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Respectfully, I pray the House to vary the order of Business to take the item numbered 10 (b) (i) and (ii).

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. An application is given to us to vary the order of Business.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we do not have any difficulty in varying the order of Business to lay that. But I want to find out from the Second Deputy Majority Whip if he said the item numbered 10 (b) (i), (ii) and (iii).

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we are taking the item numbered 10 (b) (i) and (ii). Last two weeks, I told the House that the Minister has given an indication to withdraw the Amendment Bill in the item numbered 10 (iii). So, we are not dealing with it today.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 10 (b) (i), let me take note of this well. That was by the Committee Chairman. And the (ii), also by the Committee Chairman, but (iii) is not among. Very well. Hon Members, let us turn to page 3, the item numbered 10 (b) (i) by the Chairman of the Finance Committee.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, the Chairman is not around, so as the Vice-Chairman, I would want to lay the report on behalf of the Chairman.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You are the Vice-chairman?

Mr Acheampong: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, you are the Vice-Chairman and the Second Deputy Majority Whip at the same time? Let us hear you.

I did not see you bow.

PAPERS

By Mr Richard Acheampong on behalf of the Chairman —

Report of the Finance Committee on the Annual Report on the Collection and Utilisation of the African Union Import Levy for the 2024 Fiscal Year.

By Mr Richard Acheampong on behalf of the Chairman —

Report of the Finance Committee on the Indicative Debt Restructuring Terms Between the Republic Of Ghana Represented by the Ministry of Finance and the Participating Creditor Countries of the Official Creditor Committee (Austria, Belgium, Brazil, Canada, China, The Czech Republic, Denmark, Finland, France, Germany, India, Israel, Italy, Japan, The Netherlands, Norway, Saudi Arabia, South Africa, South Korea, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, Turkey, The United Kingdom, and The United States of America).

Leadership, are we turning to the item numbered 7?

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I have another application. We will take the item numbered 10 (c), the report of the Appointments Committee.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I do not understand the application of the Second Deputy Minority Whip to take the report. They have not laid a report, so how do we take the report? So, he should make the application. Mr Speaker, I do not know why the Majority Chief Whip — whether he is wearing a smock or not, I am a Dagomba man, so a smock can definitely not frighten me. So, he should make the right application and let us move on.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, like I said earlier, I pray the House that we lay the report of the Appointments Committee; that is the item numbered 10 (c).

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. The application is granted. So, you now have to lay it.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I just got instruction from the Ranking Member of the Committee that they have not even sighted the Report that they want to lay. I am not a member of the Appointments Committee, but I just received a call from the Minority Leader, who is the Ranking Member on the Appointments Committee, that they have not even sighted the Report. Because I am not a Member of the Committee and I have not participated in the vetting of

the judges, at the moment, if the Ranking Member has not sighted the Report, I do not think it is right to lay it.

So, our respected Majority Leader, a Harvard scholar, knows what to do. He should just reach out to his Colleague, let him see the Report, and we can lay it. We are here today; it is a nice Friday and that is why I am wearing white and their Chief Whip is wearing white. So, we will definitely do it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Dafeamekpor?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I believe the record will bear me out that I have just arrived. We have been busy the whole day. We are done. In fact, this Report ought to have been laid yesterday. Laying is not the same as taking it, so our procedure mandates us to lay. The Report is done. It should be laid. The final draft is being sent to the Ranking Member.

Mr Speaker, we know that, today, we ought to have sat in the morning, but because of some exigencies, the Sitting was pushed to 2 p.m. We all know why we encourage Members to be here early, so we can close early, so Members can travel. It is already past 3 p.m., so we are pleading that we lay the Report, and then whatever it is, we can reconcile our differences, and take it a short while later. So, Mr Speaker, let us lay the Report.

So, is he opposed to the request that the Report be laid? On what grounds?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Majority Chief Whip is a very experienced lawyer and a senior Member of this House. He knows that for a Report to be laid, we should have sufficient copies. And like I rightly told him —

3.27 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We should have what?

Mr Speaker, the Ranking Member of the Committee and other Members of the Committee who were part of the vetting, my able Colleague here, Hon Jerry Shaib—They have not even seen the Report. So, for that one, let us see the Report and then they can lay the Report. But at the moment, the Report is not there. Nobody has sighted the Report and it is not good procedurally to lay a Report when it is not—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Jerry Shaib.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, I am quite surprised that we are going through this process without due deference to our Side. I mean, we just came out from the Committee hearing and we have not sighted a Report. I do not think that it is fair for anybody to proceed to lay the Report when our Side have not sighted—We have not even come to any decision on the Report for us to proceed. Mr Speaker, I respectfully think that my Colleague should bear with us. At least, I do not know if there is any rush.

Because, we even think—I do not even know if this Report is a composition of all the nominees. Because that was the agreement, that let us look at all the nominees and lay the Report to that extent. But if it is a Report that—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Shaib: We have not seen it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, the Report will be taken today. But let us yield to them. Let the Minority Leader take a look at the Report. Then we will lay it and we will take it. We will take it today, no matter what. I mean, let us yield to them. To be fair, I mean, working on a document and he has not seen it. So, let us yield to them. Let us give them a few minutes to take a look at it.

Hon Dafeamekpor, please, link up with the Clerk and let us at least make sure the Leadership have copies of it.

Yes. So, can we take the Urgent Questions now?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, so, we will take 7(a). The Question by Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin. Mr Speaker, he is not here, but as usual, I think, I will offer to ask the Question on behalf of—[Laughter]

Mr Speaker, I will offer to ask the Question on his behalf.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: He wanted to do that.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think the Majority Leader is in a hurry to come to this Side. Do not worry. In four years' time, he will be here. *[Laughter]*—Do not worry. Do not be in a hurry.

Mr Speaker, with your leave, we can do the Urgent Question, but the Minority Leader, has just rushed to attend to something. So, we can start with the B and C, and by then, he would have come. We can do the B and C, and then he will come and take his own.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Anyway, so, let us turn to B. The Question stands in the name of Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku, Hon Member of Parliament for Offinso South.

Mr Seth Osei Akoto: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Order 88 (3), I have the authority to read the Question on his behalf.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: All right. You are granted the leave. So, go ahead then.

URGENT QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF LANDS AND NATURAL RESOURCES

Measures to Combat Armed Illegal Miners in Forest Reserves

Mr Seth Osei-Akoto on behalf of Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku (NPP — Offinso South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources the measures the Ministry is

taking to combat armed illegal miners who besiege our forest reserves.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Respectfully, Hon Minister.

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah) (MP): Mr Speaker, thank you. As I provided in my brief to Parliament some months ago on the status of our forests and water bodies, out of the 288 forest reserves, 44 are under siege by illegal miners and 5,000 hectares have been degraded. As I reported at the time, 9 of the forest reserves were classified as red zones where armed thugs have been deployed by illegal miners to fight forest guards from entry to do their legitimate official work.

Mr Speaker, I am glad to report that so far 8 of these red zone forest reserves have been recovered from these armed thugs, leaving one reserve, the Desiri Forest Reserve, which is still being worked on. The Ministry and the Forestry Commission were able to recover this reserve through a collaborative effort with the Ghana Armed Forces and the Ghana Police Service. Efforts are still ongoing to take over the last reserve.

Mr Speaker, again, through the effective collaboration with the Ministry of Defence, we are developing a system where the Forestry Commission will have the military to provide backup support, especially in hotspot areas or in

situations where the rapid response teams of the Forestry Commission are unable to enforce these laws.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry is also working closely with the Forestry Commission and other agencies to source support to procure key logistics to improve mobility of officers to enhance surveillance and monitoring for early detection of forest offences.

Mr Speaker, I have engaged the Attorney-General to also explore the possibility of setting up specialised courts to deal swiftly on the issues of illegal mining.

Mr Speaker, as part of efforts to garner support for this fight, the Ministry, in collaboration with key stakeholders, has intensified the sensitisation of various communities on the effects of illegal mining on the environment, human health, and the need to carry out responsible mining.

To Hon Members, the fight is a collective fight, and I call on all Members to join the fight in their respective Constituencies where illegal mining activities are predominant.

I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much.

Mr Osei-Akoto: Mr Speaker, I do not have any supplementary question but only to thank the Hon Minister for so far how he has managed the situation.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Minister, he is commending you.

Mr Buah: Thank you very much for the commendation. We will keep up the fight.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, let me go to Hon Matthew Nyindam.

Mr Matthew Nyindam: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I heard the Minister. According to him, they have been able to save some forest reserves from this illegal mining. My question to the Minister is, will he be kind enough to provide this House with the names of these reserves?

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mr Buah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I am able to inform this House that the following forest reserves which were red zones have been reclaimed, Jimira and Jimira Extension, Afao Hills Forest Reserve, Tano-Anwia Forest Reserve, Offin Shelter Belt Forest Reserve, Anwiaso East Forest Reserve, Asuanso South Forest Reserve, Subri Forest Reserve, and Asenayo Forest Reserve.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Nyindam.

Mr Nyindam: Thank you, Mr Speaker. May I find out from the Minister, the remaining reserves that are yet to be saved, what is the challenge as of now? Or what is putting or the blockage that is not allowing the Minister to save the other ones that are left?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mr Buah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I think that it is a security issue.

We are talking about a reserve that has been taken over by 10,000 people in different areas. It has to be done carefully, bearing in mind the protection of human life. A lot of work is being done but we are doing that mindfully to protect human life at the same time. Thank you.

3.37 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, we turn to the Question numbered 7(c) and it stands in the name of Hon Frederick Addy, Member for Suaman.

Yes, Hon Addy, you have the floor now.

Measures Taken to Curb Galamsey Activities in the Suaman Constituency in Light of the Recent incident at Karlo

Mr Frederick Addy (NPP—Suaman): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources what immediate measures the Ministry is taking to curb *galamsey* activities in the Suaman Constituency, particularly, in light of the recent incident at Karlo, where two individuals lost their lives in a *galamsey* pit on Friday, 14th March, 2025.

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah) (MP): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Illegal mining is a persistent challenge which has polluted our water bodies, degraded our arable lands and decimated our forest reserves. Mr Speaker, in the recent incident in the Suaman Constituency, two people inadvertently fell in a *galamsey* pit and lost their lives.

These recent happenings have sparked public outrage and immediate measures are being put in place to curb this menace. Mr Speaker, the immediate measures include a reclamation and revegetation programme.

The Government is engaging in the reclamation of illegally mined out areas in the Constituency and other affected areas to avoid such occurrences.

Community Engagement and Education.

The Ministry has intensified community engagement and awareness creation on the affairs of illegal mining. We have engaged the district assemblies and traditional authorities to come together and help in this fight.

Law Enforcement

Punishment for perpetrators of this heinous crime will be strictly enforced as is being done, to ensure deterrence to other miners who engage in this activity. We are also strengthening licensing and regulation. Mr Speaker, we are also focusing on geologically investigated areas with very good prospects to ensure that miners will get mined out areas that are very lucrative for them to mine so that we can prevent this random digging and this risk we face. I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member for Suaman? Any supplementary question?

Mr Addy: Mr Speaker, thank you. Looking at the Answer he gave, I want to ask the Minister, ever since the incident happened, has he dispatched some team members to the site to check on it? If not, may I know why?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: He wants you to take the question again?

Mr Addy: Mr Speaker, I want to ask the Hon Minister if he has ever dispatched some team members on site ever since the incident happened? If not, may I know why?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mr Buah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. The Minerals Commission at the regional level has been coordinating with the district and those engagements have taken place. We have received reports and other follow-ups. I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, I will give you one more, or is it alright?

Mr Addy: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Hon Minister if the Ministry has made any provision to cover up the pits the *galamseymen* leave uncovered after they have been driven away from the site, as far as these *galamsey* activities are concerned in the Suaman Constituency?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mr Buah: Yes, the Ministry, through the Minerals Commission, is able to regulate small-scale miners that have legal licences. But that is why we call these activities illegal. These are illegal activities and those faceless people who do it are unknown. And so, we continue to work with the district assemblies and authorities to apprehend them and make sure they are punished and get them to recover these areas. We will continue to do so. I thank you.

Mr Addy: Mr Speaker, thank you. This question came as a matter of

urgency because the way and manner people are dying in the area is too much. So, Mr Minister, can you give us a timeline for us to know when these people will be attended to? Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, as I stated, we are engaged in a very aggressive programme. First, to reclaim all these degraded lands to minimise those risks. We are also working on a programme for cooperative mining to identify mineralised areas and organise mining in a very sustainable and responsible manner. We believe that those steps will help address the concerns that have been raised. I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Let us now turn to the Question in the name of Osahen Afenyo-Markin.

Yes, Hon Matthew Nyindam?

Mr Matthew Nyindam: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. I want to find out from the Hon Minister if he has called for some investigation into the deaths of these two individuals who, unfortunately, died as stated in the Order Paper?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, when people engage in illegalities and it results in their death, it becomes a matter of police

investigation and the right institutions are on top of this. I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Kabiru?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister and the President assured the good people of Ghana that the issue at hand can be dealt with within a matter of weeks. I want to find out why the Minister has not got a firm grip of the issue of *galamsey* and the associated loss of lives even though it has taken us half a year?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

As the President recently stated, we are under no illusion that illegal mining activities that are widespread in more than five regions and is engaged in by almost three million people will come to an end in four months. But we are very proud of the steps we have taken and the progress we are making.

We are very proud to have reclaimed eight out of nine red zones that were not tackled for over three years. We are very proud of the active collaboration we are having with the community leaders. We will continue to make the progress and make sure mining is done responsibly and sustainably in Ghana.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Kabiru, let me give you a last opportunity.

3.47 p.m.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, is that an admission from the Minister that the Government, though there are some progress being made, has failed the good people of Ghana in respect of their own promise and the fight against the illegal mining menace in Ghana?

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I think my Statement was very clear. This Government and the people of Ghana can testify that the load that we were sunk in, this Government, the last four months is really making progress and will continue to make progress to ensure that we can do mining responsibly and sustainably in Ghana.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we will continue the question but indulge me for five minutes.

3.49 p.m. — *Sitting suspended*

3.51 p.m. — *Sitting resumed*

[MR SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER
IN THE CHAIR]

Hon Members, let me thank you for your indulgence. So, let us turn to the first Question.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have a preliminary matter for you to determine. Mr Speaker, our rules do not

allow for strangers to come into the Chamber. You suspended the House for five minutes and our Colleagues allowed their National Chairman to enter the Chamber to take pictures and as part of his campaign, courting the support of NDC MPs, the National Chairman of the NDC, who has declared his intention to succeed President Mahama, *[Interruption]*—has entered the Chamber. Mr Speaker, 60 NDC MPs have taken pictures with him, declaring they are—I am told 20 more joined to make it 80.

[Interruption]

Mr Speaker, I want the Chairman to know that, the 80 is not enough. He should get more to make him the preferred candidate.

But Mr Speaker, just to conclude, I want to know whether the rules allow flag-bearer hopefuls to enter the Chamber—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, if it is allowed, then in NPP we have quite a number. We would let them also come here and take pictures. Mr Speaker, rule on this matter for me.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, do you have something to say?

Mr Ayariga: I was not here, Mr Speaker.

[Laughter]

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: The only person who was a witness to this matter was Hon Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami

Dafeamekpor. He is the only one who saw it. As for Majority Leader, he was nowhere nearby. I do not want you to call him as a witness on this matter.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The point is, it is not a question of who saw those who took the pictures. But you are raising an issue as to whether it is allowed. So that is why I am inviting him.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Chairman of the NDC was in this House for, I think, five terms. Each term was four years. So, by my basic mathematics. Three or four?

[Interruption]

Mr Speaker, I think later, we will take steps to verify whether it was four or three.

[Laughter]

Later on, we will take steps to verify whether it was three or four.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: But again, he has been a Member of the Parliamentary Service Board.

Mr Ayariga: He was a Chairman of the Board of the Parliamentary Service - at a time when you also served as a Member of that Board as an ex-Officio Member of that Board.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: He was a Human Resource (HR) Committee Board Chair.

Mr Ayariga: He was an HR Committee Chair who employed and interviewed the promotion of many of your Clerks. By virtue of that, he is entitled once in a while to pass by and see if everything is all right in the Chamber. Whether the facilities that he facilitated the procurement of are working well for us.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Speaker, and of course, being the charismatic leader that he is, being the charismatic Chairman that he is, all the MPs are excited to see him.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Speaker, I was not in the Chamber. I was in the Clerks-at-the-Table's lobby and you know there is a television there that captures what is happening in the Chamber. I saw NPP Members of Parliament struggling to take photographs with him. I saw it with my naked eyes.

[Laughter]

Mr Speaker, before he entered the Chamber, the Leader himself rushed to receive him. —*[Hear! Hear!]*— I was there. —*[Laughter]*—When the Leader received him, hugged him, and welcomed him to the Chamber. I was there, Mr Speaker, I was there. But you see, this is a Leader who wants to take the benefit and leave his Backbenchers. —*[Laughter]*— So, when his Backbenchers seize the opportunity to also have photographs with the National Chairman of the NDC, he is aggrieved.

Mr Speaker, I think that the Chairman of the NDC is here—Normally we invite him, he sits in the Chamber to witness Proceedings. On Ceremonial occasions, we invite him. He is allowed to enter the Chamber. The Chairman of the NPP is also allowed. Even the General Secretary and National Executives of the NPP also come and they are allowed to come into the Chamber. So, I do not think that there is a problem with that.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we have a lot of work to do so, can we continue?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, we can continue. Hon Habib Iddrisu?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, listening to the Majority Leader, it is very clear to me that he wants to be the running mate to Asiedu Nketia because, Mr Speaker, it turned into a campaign. When about 80 MPs declared their support to the National Chairman—Mr Speaker, when they were declaring, I took a video. I have a video on my phone. When they were declaring their support to the National Chairman. Now the Majority Leader wants to be the running mate to Asiedu Nketia and it is just six months into their Government. So, when the Chief of Staff, Hon Julius Debrah, is meeting the Metropolitan, Municipal, District Chief Executives (MMDCEs), MPs are declaring their support to Asiedu Nketia. So, Asiedu Nketia, *fa baako*, MPs, *enna* Julius *fa* DCEs. That is what is going on in the NDC. So, Mr

Speaker, we can continue with as the Majority Leader said.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, it is enough. The National Chairman of the NDC has been a Member of the House. He has been a Member of the Board and he is always a special guest. So, once he comes, I think there is no issue and the picture was taken at the time the house has been suspended. So, Hon Members, let us move on.

Let me invite the Hon—Kofi, just resume your seat.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, does that mean that you have ruled on this matter?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, my ruling is that—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: When you say the House is suspended, the mace, the symbol of authority of Parliament is a mace. That is why even when you suspend, we must bow to the mace.

Mr Speaker, the National Chairman entered the Chamber of Parliament to campaign. If it is your ruling.

[Interruption]

Mr Speaker, the National Chairman of the National Democratic Congress entered the Chamber of Parliament when the mess was very upright. Mr Speaker, I want you to rule on this matter. Mr Speaker, what is your ruling?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: My ruling is that—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the House has not been adjourned. Mr Speaker, do not be led into temptation.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Why have you invited me to rule?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you rule.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Members, like I said, Chairman Asiedu Nketia was once a Member of the House. He has been a Board Member. I served with him and he is always a special guest. So, once he comes and there is a Sitting, he is not cannot sit at the gallery. He is sitting at the special guest area.

You have the public gallery and you have a Speaker's special guest area. So, once he is sitting at the Speaker's special guest area, I do not think there is any issue and it is not only restricted to him.

Like the Majority Leader said...

4.01 p.m.

[MR SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER]

Once he is sitting at the Speaker's Special Guest Area, I do not think there is any issue and it is not only restricted to him. Like the Majority Leader said, when the leadership of the New Patriotic Party (NPP) come, they will also be welcomed. I do not think there is any

issue at all. The ruling is that there is no issue. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Yes, Hon Armah-Kofi Buah, please, take your seat. We have so many things to do today. Osahen, you have to ask your Question now, please.

URGENT QUESTION

MINISTRY OF LANDS AND NATURAL RESOURCES

Unhindered Access to the Concession at Bogoso Prestea Gold Mine

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (NPP — Effutu): Mr Speaker, with respect, I rise to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, the steps the Ministry is taking to ensure that Future Global Resources Limited and Blue Gold Holdings Limited gain unhindered access to their legally acquired concession at Bogoso Prestea Gold Mine.

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah): Mr Speaker, Future Global Resources Limited and Blue Gold Holdings Limited are no longer the holders of the Bogoso Prestea mining leases, effective 18th September, 2024. Mr Speaker, the then Minister, Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, terminated the mining leases granted the companies acting on the advice and recommendation of the Minerals Commission and the immediate past Attorney-General, Godfred Yeboah Dame, pursuant to Article 88 of the

Constitutions, Sections 51, 68 and 100 of the Minerals and Mining Act, 2006 (Act 703), and Regulation 201 of the Minerals and Mining (Licencing) Regulations (L. I. 2176).

Mr Speaker, the above decision was based on breaches of the terms of the mining leases of the company pursuant to Section 68 of Act 703, as I have stated, and Section 27 of the terminated mining lease agreements executed between the Republic and the companies. Mr Speaker, it is, therefore, clear, that at the time of taking over as Minister, Future Global Resources Limited and Blue Gold Holdings Limited no longer had concessions at the Bogoso Prestea mine.

I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do you have any supplementary questions?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Rightly so. Mr Speaker, this is a house of records, and our rules tell us to proceed with caution.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister in his Answer is very categorical that the former Minister, and he mentioned him by name, Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, terminated this agreement against the advice of the former Attorney-General —**[Mr Buah:** No, on the advice and recommendation.]—

Mr Speaker, Questions are asked for Answers, so that there will be clarity. If the Minister says that there was some advice on record, I want to know, and he

should be very clear, whether there was any such advice documented from the Office of the Attorney-General.

Mr Speaker, I will not pursue that, but I will ask him whether he is aware that with water levels rising to 19, it will be near impossible to resuscitate the mine if dewatering is not commissioned immediately, considering the situation we find ourselves in.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, the Question was on the status of Blue Gold Holdings Limited and whether they had a mining lease. If the Hon Member wants to talk about the current situation of the mine of Bogoso, I think he can come with a substantive Question.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Member, you got him.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, respectfully, I do not want to litigate this afternoon with my respected Colleague, because I have some indication from the Majority Leader on some other important things that the Government wants to do, which will require our cooperation. But Mr Speaker, if the Hon Minister would pay attention to my question again, and by the way, I do a lot of preparation before I come; so, he should not just make the point that I have asked whether or not there is a lease.

My Question was to ask him the steps being taken to ensure that Future Gold Resources Limited and Blue Gold Holdings Limited gain unhindered access. So, I have premised my Question

on the fact that they do not have access and it is affecting their investments. So, if I now come and ask him whether he is aware that with the water level rising to 19, it will be near impossible to resuscitate the mine if dewatering is not commissioned immediately, I am anchoring it on the very Answer he gave in respect to the access.

If the company does not have access, what it means is that they are unable to do their work, and I was drawing his attention. Mr Speaker, one of the issues they raised in their letter to the President, which the Attorney-General responded to, has to do with the investment which is going bad, and this affects the image of the country. They have written twice to the President; so, if I am asking him, by way of supplementary question, to address this House as to whether there would be no problem should they not get access now, how does he then tell me that I should come under a substantive Question?

Mr Speaker, I do not understand. No, I do not understand.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I would not have stopped him from responding —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Do not worry; let us make progress.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We always say that we bring Ministers here to respond to specific Questions, and that this House is a house of records. So, we

bring a Minister here, you ask him a Question, and subsequently, you ask him questions which may not be a question that he has prepared for. He may give Answers, and it will turn out not to be. Please, let us give them the opportunity —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we can make progress.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: If you still want him to respond to that, you can come by way of another Question.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, if it is your ruling that it amounts to a substantive Question, I will yield to you because that is your ruling. So, let us make progress.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, and it is for all of us because we do not want the Ministers to come and —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we can make progress. That is fine.

Mr Speaker, is the Minister aware that as a result of the company not having access to its legally acquired mine, the illegal miners are ravaging the underground operators on a daily basis because the underground workers do not have access? Is he aware of that?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, are you listening to him?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: He would not pay attention; he is rather discussing — You see?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, in my earlier Answer to the Question of the Hon Minority Leader, which was on the legal status of the companies, Blue Gold Holdings Limited and Future Global Resources Limited, whether they still own the mine, and that they should be allowed legal access to the concession, my Answer was that their concession was terminated by the previous Government and the previous Government gave the mine to a new company. They have no legal access to the mine. That is the Answer.

Now, if he wants to ask questions about the status of the mine and the status of the performance of a new company that is performing, he should ask another Question. I will come prepared and Answer that.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, it is quite rich, very rich, that the Minister stood at the dispatch box to tell the whole nation that this company does not have access because the contract has been terminated —*[Interruption]*— The concession, yes. By the way, is the Minister aware that the company has written to the President, complaining about the inability to have access, for which the opinion of the Attorney-General has been sought?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister. Is the President or the Minister aware? Minister, are you aware?

4.11 p.m.

Mr Buah: I can only speak about communications that I am copied. I have not been copied on any such letters.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Hon Minister, since we are now talking about official communications that the Hon Minister is copied, may I know whether this company has approached the office of the Minister, as part of their effort at gaining access to their mine?

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, I think he is capable of answering. Yes, Leader, let me hear you.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, I am coming. Last year, Osahen Afenyo-Markin was on the Majority Side and he was coaching; he was trying to guide. So that is the role of Leaders, and you are all the same.

Yes, Leader, let me hear you.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the focus of the question is on efforts to assist two mining companies to have access to a mine, and the Minister has given an answer that those companies do not have the right because that right was terminated by the New Patriotic Party (NPP) Government at a time when Osahen Afenyo-Markin was the Leader

of Government Business. His government, NPP, brought a new company and gave the new company rights to that concession. Now, is he asking the Minister to engage in an illegality by forcefully allowing a company that legally has no rights?

Mr Speaker, I do not think all these lines of questions follow from the Question. As to whether they approached the Minister or they went to his office or whether they went to His Excellency the President, among others—I think we should be clear. The Minister has about 15 Questions today. So, we should move away from that. We should ask questions that flow from your original Questions.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, I appreciate where you are coming from. I know we have a way of handling the Leaders, but I think the Question is such that the Minister is capable of answering them. I will yield to him. So, that is why I asked if the Minister is minded to respond. Other than that, we can still move on. So Minister, the question he asked, are you prepared to respond to it?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, I think the rules of this House on Questions are very clear and the Ministers have come prepared to deal with the Question as has been asked. I came prepared to answer a Question on the legality and whether or not Future Global Resources Limited and Blue Gold have legal access to a concession in Bogoso, and I came to say they do not. My good Friend, the Minority Leader, wants me to come and talk about the state of the Bogoso Mine.

That is another matter altogether. I will be happy to come and do it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Minority Leader, you may ask another question.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Would the Hon respected Colleague and Minister be able to make available to Parliament, this communication that according to him terminated the lease?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, for the record, the rules are very clear. The Technical Advisor to the Minister, the regulator, will normally advise the Minister on the grounds for termination. The Minister, based on that advice and the advice from the Attorney-General, will now write to advice and direct the Minerals Commission to go ahead with the termination.

I have gone through the records and I can say that the former Minister followed the spirit and letter of that law. He got the Technical Advice and the reasons why there has to be termination. He also got the legal advice from the Attorney-General and based on that, those terminations were done. Those records are there and the Ministry will be happy to provide that.

Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, when an Hon Member asks a Question and the Minister pushes the Hon Member

to act right, the Hon Member acts right. The Hon Minister tries to trivialise the main answer and this becomes problematic. He said on record that they have no such right because the lease agreement was terminated. It follows the logic and that logic begs for an answer, evidence. All I am asking is if he can make that available to Parliament for its records? Because he is on record. Can he make that termination letter available? He did not say maybe it is public—He should make it available and then commit to it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Minister, I think you have to answer. Can you make the termination document available?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, the Ministry will make available all records that can be made public to this House.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Minority Leader, your last question.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, that is all for him. But Mr Speaker, I will beg of you, since he is in possession of this termination letter, the practice has normally, always been that Ministers will come accompanied with it because that is what they rely on. When the Majority Leader intervened, he said that no such rights exist, which I agree, legally. So, I am ready to go and come back. Can he give a timeline? Is he able to bring it on Monday, Tuesday or Wednesday?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, let us give him time.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you need to direct.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, can you tell the House as to when you can give us a copy of the termination letter?

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker today is Friday. I am sure next week I will be able to provide it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, I take it that by next week Friday, you will have the report. Very well. Alhaji Habib Iddrisu?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I want to draw your attention to Article 102 of the 1992 Constitution. I read Article 102:

“A quorum of Parliament, apart from the person presiding, shall be one-third of all Members of Parliament.”

Mr Speaker, I am fortified by Order 64. Order 64 of our Standing Order says that:

“A quorum of Parliament apart from the person presiding, is one-third of all Members of Parliament.”

Mr Speaker, I have taken count of us in the Chamber and we are 69. We are not up to one-third, which is 91.

Mr Speaker, so I invite you to respect the Constitution. I know you are a

lawyer, and you respect the Constitution of the Republic of Ghana and what has been stated. For us not to debate much about this issue, just adjourn the House, because we do not have 91 Members to continue.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Are you mindful of the fact that it is your own people who have Questions to ask?

4.21p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip, let me hear you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I am scandalised by the present Motion being moved by the First Deputy Minority Whip. Mr Speaker, the Minority Side are 23 in number while the Majority Side as I stand on my feet are 72 in number; I did the counting. He came to engage me. *[Interruption]*— Yes, because he ordered them to step out. This is a political mischief and should not be countenanced at all. We are 73 and they are 23. Mr Speaker, the request by the First Minority Whip is totally out of place; he has no basis. He could not even tell how many are on the Majority Side, and how many on the Minority Side constitute the number. Mr Speaker, we have the numbers to continue to do business, and we will have the numbers to take a decision when we get there.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Speaker, we have already spent a lot of precious parliamentary time today, we cannot spend any more time without

doing precious business. I pray that we proceed to continue to do business. In any case, Order 64 of our Standing Orders is very clear and it is that Order that provides the procedure on how this matter should be handled. So, if the Chair is minded to pay any attention to what he is saying, we are willing to deal with that matter under Order 64. Mr Speaker, I urge you to ignore the request by the First Minority Whip so that we can make progress.

I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Minority Whip?

Alhaji Habib: Mr Speaker, I have raised a constitutional matter and it does not lie on me or the Majority Chief Whip to tell you the number in the Chamber. It is a constitutional matter, Mr Speaker. And in any case, we on this Side are not even up to 23. Mr Speaker, the constitutional matter I have raised is in respect of Article 102 and I invite you to do the needful. The Majority Chief Whip is not the one to provide you with the number neither am I the one to provide you with the number. But the point is that we are not up to 91 in this Chamber.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Member, the fact of the matter is that I have done the counting myself. The Clerk-at-the-Table has also done the counting and at the moment, we are 97—

[Hear! Hear!]—Therefore, we can do business. So, Hon Members, let us move on.

[Interruptions]—

Let us now turn to the normal questions—Question 53 and the Question stands in the name of Hon Anthony Mmieh, Member of Parliament for Odotobri.

Yes, Hon Member, you may ask your Question now?

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY FOR LANDS AND NATURAL RESOURCES

Ensuring Easier and Cheaper Registration of Land

Mr Anthony Mmieh (NPP—Odotobri): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources what the Ministry intends to do to ensure easier and cheaper registration of lands under the Lands Act 2020, (Act 1036).

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources (Mr Emmanuel Armah-Kofi Buah): Mr Speaker, the high cost and delay in the registration of land can be attributed to the manual processes involved and the requirement to prepare a cadastral plan for each application. This calls for a survey of each and every

application which increases the cost of registration.

To address this challenge, the Lands Commission, with the support of the Ministry, is in the process of implementing a Land Administration Reform which aims at:

- (i) Production of digital maps across the country;
- (ii) Digitalise the processes of the Commission; and
- (iii) Decentralisation among others.

Mr Speaker, the Lands Commission, on its own, using part of its Internally Generated Funds (IGF), has initiated some digital processes but in order to extend the processes and services to all regions, there is a need to obtain funding from private sources, (Private-Public Partnership- PPP), where the private sector will finance the activities, whilst the Commission pays back over a period of time through its IGF. This project, when implemented, will go a long way to reduce the turnaround time for registration and also reduce the cost of registration.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry will soon present a paper for the Commission to be allowed to retain 100 per cent of its IGF instead of the current 33 per cent and to basically address this effort. This, among other measures, will go a long way to address the challenges that have been raised in the question.

I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Mmieh, any supplementary question?

Mr Mmieh: Thank you, Hon Minister.

I have a follow-up supplementary question. My supplementary is that, he has indicated certain initiatives to be embarked on by the Ministry—three of them; the production of digital maps across the country, digitalisation of the processes of the Commission, as well as decentralisation, among others. I would be grateful if he could inform this House if the Ministry has a roadmap and timelines for the three initiatives.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Buah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry is already implementing some of the plans and programmes that have been outlined. First, the Lands Commission has been directed and working with the District Assemblies to make sure that they have presence in every district in the country and we are not going to wait for digitalisation for that to start. We are going to start small and make sure that, at, least we have presence in each district to basically reduce the cost for people across remote areas who must travel to regional capitals to have access to land services and that implementation should take place by the end of July this year. We must at least have one staff member in every district.

We have already engaged the Ministry of Finance and the Lands Commission and we have had a very fruitful engagement on the issue of retention.

The Ministry of Finance has been very welcoming to our proposals and so we are making progress in a lot of the areas that I have discussed. Thank you.

4.31 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Anthony Mmieh?

Mr Mmieh: Thank you, Hon Minister. Now my final supplementary question for the Question numbered 53. Has the Ministry considered education and creation of awareness in respect of what the Minister has said? I am raising this issue because almost everybody wants to acquire land or has acquired land in Ghana.

When it comes to registration, we have not done too well. There is a lot of ignorance when it comes to land matters, legal matters relating to land and particularly, registration of lands. Would the Minister consider embarking on a massive education or creation of awareness to inform every Ghanaian about these initiatives?

Mr Buah: Indeed, the Hon Member is right. The new Land Act has new provisions that calls for a lot of education. The Lands Commission has

begun some public engagements but it has to be intensified, and I can assure the Member that we will take his call for intensifying education among the populace and we will do that. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Mahama?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, following from the Answer he gave in respect of the national land policy, specifically on digitisation, I recall that the previous government started the land digitilisation project with the Lands Commission leading the process. I want to find out what the state of that initiative as he met it is and how is he improving it to ensure its completion. Thank you.

Mr Buah: As he said, Government is a continuous process. We have already reviewed some of the progress that has been made with the digitalisation efforts. The new Lands Commission leadership is looking at where the effort was reached and we are taking it from there. We intend to intensify the digitalisation effort.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, we will turn to Question 54 and the Question stands in the name of the same person and that is Hon Anthony Mmieh, Hon Member for Odotobri.

Efforts to Implement New National Land Policy

Mr Anthony Mmieh (NPP — Odotobri): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources the efforts the Ministry is making to implement a new National Land Policy since the old Policy is outdated and does not address current needs.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, the 1999 National Land Policy has guided the sector for 25 years. The 2022 National Land Conference called for a review of the National Land Policy to ensure that;

- It is up to date with current development imperatives in the country.
- It addresses the emerging issues since 1999.
- It aligns with international instruments on land governance and land management.
- Participatory and inclusive methodologies are adopted.

A committee has therefore been established to:

- a. Review the extent to which the National Land Policy of 1999 has been implemented.
- b. Identify emerging issues that should be considered in a revised National Land Policy.

c. Prepare a draft revised National Land Policy.

Mr Speaker, a roadmap has been developed to guide the process. GIZ is supporting Government's effort by providing two consultants to support the process. The review process will therefore commence very soon.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Mr Mmieh: Mr Speaker, there will be none.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, so we turn to the Question numbered 97 which stands in the name of Hon Kofi Obiri Yeboah.

Plans to Ensure Protection of Legitimate Land Owners

Mr Kofi Obiri Yeboah (NPP — Subin): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources the plans of the Ministry to ensure that land owners who acquired state lands legitimately are protected.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources has started inaugurating the Regional Lands Commissions in all regions after which the National Lands Commission which is the main decision-making body will be inaugurated.

Mr Speaker, the Commission will be expected to review all land allocations and leases and make appropriate

recommendations to the Ministry for implementation. I can assure the Hon Member that land owners who have acquired land legitimately and meet the value of money threshold will be protected.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Kofi Obiri Yeboah, do you have any supplementary questions?

Mr Obiri Yeboah: No, Mr Speaker. That will be all.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, we will take your next substantive Question which is the Question numbered 98.

Lifting of Ban on Lands Commission in Respect of Sales, Lease and Processing of Transactions.

Mr Kofi Obiri Yeboah (NPP—Subin): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources when the ban placed on the Lands Commission in respect of sales, lease and processing of transactions involving state and public lands will be lifted.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, the Ministry has begun a programme to sanitise the processes for sales, lease and the processing of state and public lands. Mr Speaker, the Ministry working with the Ministry of Works, Housing and Water Resources, under a cabinet directive, have constituted a five-member committee to review all state and public lands transactions. When the committee completes its work, appropriate

recommendations will be made to the cabinet for direction.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr Obiri Yeboah: Mr Speaker, can the Hon Minister tell the House the timelines assigned to the committee to finish their job?

Mr Buah: The committee is expected to finish their work by the middle of July, and we hope to be able to present our report by the end of that month. I thank you.

Mr Obiri Yeboah: Mr Speaker, that will be all.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to the Question numbered 113 which stands in the name of Hon Richmond Edem Kofi Kpotosu, Member for Ho Central.

Plans to Reclaim Devastated Lands used for Illegal Mining

Mr Richmond Edem Kofi Kpotosu (NDC — Ho Central): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources the plans of the Ministry to reclaim the devastated lands which were used for illegal mining.

4.41 p.m.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, there are several interventions that my Ministry is putting in place to reclaim all the mined-out areas, and key among them is the Tree for Life Restoration Initiative,

which was launched by the H.E President John Dramani Mahama in March 2025. This initiative seeks to embark on transformational landscape restoration efforts to heal and harness the environment by turning areas heavily degraded by illegal mining and other drivers of deforestation and forest degradation, into ecologically functional landscapes.

Mr Speaker, a total area of 500 hectares of impacted forest reserves have been earmarked to be reclaimed in Ashanti, Western and Western North Regions in 2025. Other degraded landscapes outside forest reserves will also be reclaimed under various projects such the Ghana Landscape Restoration and Small-Scale Mining Project and the National Alternative Employment and Livelihood Programme.

Mr Speaker, the tree planting exercise under the Tree for Life Reforestation initiative officially commenced on 5th June and this will continue throughout the rainy season.

I wish to implore all Hon Members to actively participate in this tree planting exercise, which has a planting target of 30 million seedlings in 2025.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member for Ho Central, any supplementary questions?

Mr Kpotosu: Thank you, Mr Speaker; I am done.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You are done. Very well.

Hon Members, let us turn to the Question numbered 123, owned by Hon Robert Wisdom Cudjoe, Member of Parliament for Prestea Huni-Valley.

Dr Eric Afful: Mr Speaker, I have the authority of the Member of Parliament to ask the Question on his behalf.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the application has been granted; you can go on.

Account on Total Cost of Operations of the Inter-Ministerial Committee

Dr Eric Afful on behalf of Mr Robert Wisdom Cudjoe (NDC — Prestea Huni-Valley): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to account for the total cost of operations of the Inter-Ministerial Committee set up in 2017 by the previous Administration to fight against illegal mining, the total assets seized, and their current status.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources has no records on the total cost of the operations of the Inter-Ministerial Committee set up in 2017. I am, therefore, unable to provide the accurate responses to this Question posed by the Hon Member for Prestea Huni-Valley, as the Inter-Ministerial Committee set up in 2017, under the previous Administration, was under the then Ministry of Environment, Science, Technology and Innovations.

I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do you have the authority of the Member to ask supplementary questions?

Dr Afful: Mr Speaker, currently, I do not have, but I would like to thank the Minister for a prompt and a quick Answer.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, thank you very much.

We will now take the last Question, the Question numbered 111. Hon Minister, do you not have it? You have it.

Hon Members, the Question numbered 111, and it stands in the name of the Hon Member for Atwima Mponua, Mr Seth Osei-Akoto.

Mr Frank Yeboah: Mr Speaker, I come under Order 88(3) of our Standing Orders, and with your leave, to ask the Question —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Your application is granted; go ahead.

Mr Yeboah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Efforts to Stop Illegal Mining in Selected Forest Reserves

Mr Frank Yeboah on behalf of Mr Seth Osei-Akoto (NPP — Atwima Mponua): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the

Minister for Lands and Natural Resources the efforts being made to stop illegal mining of three (3) forest reserves, namely: (i) Jimira Forest Reserve around Adobewura (ii) Offin Shelter Belt Apenkro (iii) Asenanyo Reserve around Tahoma.

Mr Buah: Mr Speaker, through effective collaboration with the Military High Command, the Forestry Commission secured the services of the military for patrolling these hot-spot areas in the Nkawie Forest District to confront the illegal mining activities in the area.

Four joint Forestry Commission/Military operations have been undertaken between February and May 2025 which resulted in confiscation of 35 excavators, one bulldozer, and one pick up vehicle.

Mr Speaker, eight suspects have also been arrested — three in Jimira and five in the Offin Shelter Belt Forest Reserve, and are currently standing trial at the Circuit Court in Kwadaso for offences related to illegal mining.

Mr Speaker, plans are underway to secure the services of military personnel to be stationed at the various hot-spot Forest Districts to provide backup support as I have indicated in my earlier response.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, any supplementary questions?

Mr Yeboah: Mr Speaker, no supplementary questions.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, we bring Questions time to a close. On behalf of the House, I would like to thank the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources for attending upon the House to answer Questions from his own Colleagues.

Hon Minister, we are grateful, and you are hereby discharged.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, this is a Friday; I think we can take an adjournment.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I second the Motion ably moved by the Majority Leader.

[Pause]

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the *avant-garde* of Government Business is whipping his Members. His Members are not up to; he is struggling. He knows he does not have the numbers to take a decision, so he is eating a humble pie and has reported to his Majority Leader. So, the Majority Leader has asked for adjournment. Mr Speaker, if they do not have the numbers and they are asking for adjournment, we will yield to it. We will yield.

Mr Speaker, anything the Majority Leader would want to say after I have spoken, do not take him seriously. He can say anything; I will not mind him.
[Laughter]

[Pause]

4.51 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The Motion has not been moved. Majority Leader, did you move the Motion? Leader, move the motion.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, what he does not know is that you have become a very experienced Speaker, because I actually did not move. Mr Speaker, I actually did not move and you were clear. You observed that I did not move. Mr Speaker, I said we may take an adjournment and the reason is simple.

The Minority Leader is the Ranking Member on the Appointments Committee. Mr Speaker, he and his Chairman are supposed to present to us the Report of their Committee. Mr Speaker, they have not completed the Report of their Committee. If the Report is not ready, we cannot take it. The Report is not ready —[Uproar]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, what about the laying?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, you have the final decision. I think we can take the laying of the Reports in the Order Paper *Addendum*. I only suggested that we may take an adjournment, but if in your wisdom, we should just take the Reports, we can take them.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, we are just laying — No, it is not the Report of the Appointments Committee.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we do not have any copy of any Order Paper *Addendum* here, and when a Motion has been moved and seconded, you need to take a decision on that.

Mr Speaker, what you are doing is alien to our rules. The Majority Leader said we may take an adjournment and it has been seconded, nothing has been done, then you put it aside and you are doing something else. I do not know where these rules are from.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, as you rightly pointed out, a Motion has not been moved for adjournment; so, there is no Motion to be seconded, and you have drawn attention to the existence of an *Addendum*. Mr Speaker, so, even though the Report of the Appointments Committee is not ready—[Interruption]—Mr Speaker, we can conduct a search on that table. He just took his copy away.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Yes, Mr Speaker, it is on the screen, on our individual monitors. They should just check. We are just laying two Reports.

Mr Speaker, I think there is consensus. The Chairman is not there.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, let us take the adjournment.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, in the absence of the Chairman and the

Ranking Member, let us go ahead and take the adjournment.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Move the Motion for adjournment.

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I beg to move that this House adjourns until Tuesday, 24th June, 2024, at 2 p.m.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, having realised he has no numbers, I second the Motion.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion for adjournment has been moved and it has been seconded.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

This House is accordingly adjourned till Tuesday, 24th June, 2025 at two o'clock in the afternoon.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 4.55 p.m. till Tuesday, 24th June, 2025 at 2.00 p.m.

Editor's Note

This Official Report was corrected by the House on 2nd July, 2025.

Column 38, paragraph 4, line 2, “d” was added to “programme”.